A Little Christmas Mischief

A coloring page and an opening excerpt from
Accidentally Inheriting a Duke at Christmas



Jesse Alexander

The story begins

An opening excerpt from Accidentally Inheriting a Duke at Christmas. Copyright 2026 Jesse Alexander.

The public coach stank of damp wool and other people's despair. Ashton pressed closer to the frost-rimed window, watching London blur past in shades of grey and white. Salt water choking his lungs. Six weeks lost to fever dreams that melted his bones. Then months of stumbling across Portugal, Spain, and half of bloody France until some acquaintance finally recognized him and pressed sufficient coin into his hand to send him home.

Home.

His breath fogged the glass. He rubbed it away with a gloved hand. The leather was cracked now, salt-stained and foreign. Everything felt foreign. His greatcoat hung wrong. His body moved like a stranger's.

But home would fix that.

A bath hot enough to scald the shipwreck and nightmare journey from his skin. His own bed, not some flea-ridden inn mattress. Silence. Blessed order. Servants moving with the hush of proper mourning. Black crepe draping every window, keeping the world outside until he found his footing again.

The coach lurched over another rut. Ashton's jaw clenched against the ache in his back. Nearly there. The streets had turned familiar, lined with townhouses that knew their place in the world.

Then the coach slowed.

Aylesford House rose before him, and something was wrong. Very wrong.

Every window blazed with light. Every single one. The unused third floor. Even the servants' quarters. Golden warmth spilled across the snow-dusted street.

And was that... laughter?

He climbed down from the coach and paid the driver. Then he stood there, staring at his own home glowing like a tavern on Twelfth Night.

Someone had carelessly left the front door ajar. Just enough for light to pour onto the steps, melting the fresh snow into dark patches. The brass knocker with his family crest, three centuries old, wore a crown of evergreen boughs tied with red ribbon.

Red.

Not black.

What in God's name—

Music drifted out. A pianoforte, played with more enthusiasm than skill, accompanied by voices raised in something that might charitably be called song.

Ashton's breath came shorter. This was not a house in mourning. This was not order or silence or anything resembling proper grief.

This was a damned party.

He stood frozen on his own doorstep, staring at the evergreen-wrapped knocker like it had personally betrayed him.

Someone inside shrieked with laughter.

Warm air spilled through the open door and struck his frozen face. Ashton stood there, confusion rooting him to his own doorstep. Should he knock? The thought was absurd. This was his bloody house. His inheritance. His sanctuary. Yet who would dare throw a party in his absence? Who had such audacity? Even his Great Aunt Ellena would find it vulgar and crass.

He could creep in like a thief, take measure of these home invaders and revelers. The idea rankled. No. He would not knock. Would not touch that betraying garland with its red ribbon that should be black as night, black as the mourning his household should be drowning in.

His gloved fingers found the door's edge. It swung open easily, silently on hinges that had always been stiff in winter. The familiar creak that announced visitors, that soft complaint a quarter of the way open... gone. Someone had oiled them. Someone had touched his townhouse, changed it, made it strange and wrong.

Pine garlands strangled every surface. The entrance hall, which should smell of beeswax and proper English restraint, reeked of cinnamon and cloves. Bright lights blazed from every sconce, every chandelier.

I survived drowning only to die of bewilderment in my own foyer!

The marble floor gleamed. Not just clean but polished to mirror brightness. Fresh holly crowned every portrait. His ancestors gazed down through frames wrapped in evergreen, looking somehow less disapproving than usual.

A crash echoed from somewhere deeper in the house, followed by more laughter. Male voices. Young. Happy.

His jaw tightened.

Movement caught his eye. An unfamiliar footman came barreling around the corner, arms overflowing with holly branches, and nearly crashed straight into him.

"Oh! Beg pardon, sir." The boy's cheeks were flushed with exertion or wine or both. Holly scattered across the marble. "His Lordship is unavailable at present. Perhaps you could return tomorrow?"

The words hung between them.

His Lordship? In my house?

Ashton's voice, when it finally emerged, could have frosted glass.

"His Lordship."

"Yes, sir. Though if you've business with the household, Mr. Welby might..." The boy trailed off, finally taking in Ashton's appearance. The particular way aristocratic fury could fill a foyer without raising its voice.

"Where."

Not a question. A command that had sent grown men scurrying.

The boy's throat worked. "The... the courtyard, sir. They're building..."

But Ashton had already turned, following the noise through halls that should be his but felt like someone else's dream. More garlands. More light. A side table bore a tray of half-eaten mince pies. Mince pies! In his house of mourning!

The sounds grew louder. Multiple voices now, calling instructions. Someone counting. The courtyard doors stood wide despite the December cold.

He stepped through.

Snow fell in fat, lazy flakes. A bonfire crackled in the center of the courtyard, throwing wild shadows against the walls. Figures darted everywhere, servants and strangers pelting one another with snowballs.

Then he saw Welby.

Ancient, dignified Welby, who had served his father and grandfather before him. Welby who moved through the house like a ghost of proper English service. Welby who would sooner die than allow impropriety under this roof.

That very same Welby stood in the courtyard with a snowball the size of a cannonball balanced in his ancient hands.

Their eyes met across the chaos.

"Your Grace!" Welby's voice cracked like a whip. The old man dropped his snowball and fell to his knees in the snow, and whether he was thanking the Almighty for Ashton's miraculous return or begging clemency for this circus remained gloriously unclear. "Dear God, Your Grace, you're alive, you're—"

But Ashton couldn't look away from the rest of it. Mrs. Fielding, his unimpeachable housekeeper who had once lectured a parlour maid for showing an inch of ankle, had her skirts hitched to her knees like some tavern wench. She lobbed another snowball at Chef Lafarge. Ashton had never seen the man express anything beyond culinary disdain. Now the Frenchman cackled, actually *cackled*, ducking behind what appeared to be a snow fortress.

"Mon Dieu! You throw like an Englishwoman!" Lafarge shouted, scooping ammunition with both hands.

Mrs. Fielding shrieked with outrage. "I'll show you English aim, you pompous—"

"Mr. Welby, watch out!"

The warning came from somewhere beyond the bonfire. Ashton's gaze snapped toward the voice just as another man stepped into view, arm already drawn back, a snowball the size of a Christmas pudding balanced in his grip.

Time stretched like pulled taffy.

The stranger stood tall, broad shoulders filling out what looked suspiciously like Ashton's favourite riding coat. Wind had painted his cheeks crimson, and his mouth, wide and made for laughter, curved with unholy glee.

"Happy Christmas!" The stranger launched his missile with devastating precision.

But Welby was still on his knees.

The snowball sailed over the kneeling butler, directly toward Ashton's face.

He saw it coming. Saw the perfect sphere spinning through firelight and shadow. Saw his coat on another man's back. Saw his servants playing like children. Saw his house transformed into someone else's joy.

The snow exploded against his cheekbone.

Ice burst across his jaw, shattered into his eye, invaded his mouth. Cold slid beneath his collar, found every warm pocket his body had protected through weeks of hell. The taste of it, clean and sharp, mixed with something else. Humiliation. Pure, crystalline humiliation served at velocity.

The courtyard went silent.

Not the gentle hush of snowfall. The terrible quiet that precedes executions.

Ashton didn't move. Didn't blink. Snow dripped from his jaw onto his greatcoat. His eye, the one full of ice, watered freely. He stood there, Duke of Aylesford, presumed dead, recently risen, freshly assaulted by frozen water in his own home.

The stranger's mouth fell open. The jubilant grin dissolved into something spectacular. Horror mixed with disbelief, garnished with the dawning recognition that he'd just declared war on the wrong corpse.

"Oh, Lord," someone whispered. The unfamiliar footman had gone white as the snow at his feet.

Mrs. Fielding dropped her skirts. They pooled around her ankles with a wet slap.

Chef Lafarge crossed himself.

The stranger moved next, and barely. His throwing arm lowered by degrees, as if sudden movement might trigger an avalanche. Those wind-bright cheeks drained of colour.

Ashton lifted one hand. Slowly. Deliberately. Snow fell from his sleeve.

His good eye, the one not weeping ice water, fixed on the stranger wearing his coat.

The man who'd dared shout "Happy Christmas" while committing assault.

Who'd thrown that perfect sphere with perfect aim at the perfectly wrong moment.

* * *

David's laugh died in his throat. The stranger wiped snow from his face with the deliberation of a man cleaning blood off a blade.

Dark eyes that could freeze hell itself pinned David where he stood. Water dripped from coal-black hair, sliding down a jaw carved from winter stone. The droplets traced a path along a throat that David absolutely, definitely, should not be noticing right now. Not when those eyes promised murder. Elegant, aristocratic murder, but murder all the same.

"Your Grace?" Mrs. Fielding's gasp split the silence like breaking glass.

David's stomach exited through his boots. Kept going. Probably halfway to Dover by now. Maybe even Boston.

That jawline. Christ almighty, that jawline. He'd seen it every morning for two weeks in the portrait above the study fireplace. The painted eyes that tracked him while he ate breakfast at the wrong table, fixed the loose bannister, pretended he had any right to touch things that weren't his.

The Duke of Aylesford. His dead third cousin.

I just assaulted a duke. The actual Duke. My dead cousin who isn't dead.

His mouth opened. Something intelligent should come out. Something apologetic. Something that might prevent his immediate execution.

"I..."

"Inside."

One word. Soft as a knife between ribs. The Duke didn't raise his voice. Didn't need to. His command settled over the courtyard like frost.

"Now."

The servants scattered like startled birds, Mrs. Fielding yanking Tom, the new footman, by the ear, Chef Lafarge muttering rapid French that sounded suspiciously like prayers. Welby rose from his knees with considerably more dignity, though David caught him hiding what might've been the world's tiniest smile.

David moved as if he were wading through molasses. The borrowed coat suddenly weighed a thousand pounds. God, he was wearing the man's actual coat. Snow clung to his hair. Hot, prickling shame crawled up his neck as he followed the Duke's rigid spine through the doorway.

He looks at me as if I've stolen something precious.

I have.

His entire life. Even if I didn't mean to.

The study door closed behind them with the finality of a coffin lid. David stood with water dripping from his half-sodden clothing onto the marble floor, watching candlelight catch on the Duke's wet hair, and wondered if they'd hang him for treason.

Or if they made special exceptions for idiots who threw snowballs at the resurrected.

The Duke unbuttoned his greatcoat like he was removing armor before an execution. Each button released with a precision that made David's mouth go dry. He shrugged it off. Water dripped from dark hair onto the Persian rug, each drop a small accusation.

Firelight caught on sharp cheekbones, turning wet skin to gold. His white shirt, patches of it transparent with snow-melt, clung to a body that had no business looking that good after death. Near death? Almost death? David's thoughts swam in circles, trying to make sense of resurrection and inheritance and the way that damp linen outlined muscles that definitely, absolutely, should not be making his palms sweat.

The Duke's collar stuck to his throat. David tracked the movement when he swallowed.

Christ. Focus.

Those hands. Long fingers, elegant despite trembling with cold or rage, worked at his cuffs. The kind of hands that signed death warrants. Played piano. Traced jawlines in the dark.

David's chest went tight in ways that had nothing to do with fear.

He lurched toward the basket by the fireplace and grabbed a towel. A servant had left a stack there when David called everyone outside for the impromptu snowball fight, even those still in the middle of their chores. The rough-woven linen was nothing like the soft, thick towels in the Duke's bathing chamber that felt like silken wool against skin. He held it out as a peace offering.

The Duke looked at it like David was offering poison.

"I didn't know you were alive. The solicitors said—"

"The solicitors are idiots."

Shall we leave them there?

Of course not.

David has inherited a title that was never quite his. Ash has come home to find his house full of laughter, his servants in open rebellion, and a stranger wearing his coat.

Neither of them has the faintest idea what Christmas has in store.

There is more Christmas mischief waiting in *Accidentally Inheriting a Duke at Christmas*, along with an invitation at the end of the book to collect the companion coloring pages.

Continue David and Ash's story

With love,
Jesse